

of them, no matter how many of them there are. You might be surprised to find that they're fewer and farther between than you would've thought. And you may start to see a strange phenomena in which you can have transactions that are both aligned and out of alignment with your values within a single expense category.

For example, coffee.

One coffee could be aligned with your values because it gave you time with a friend or a place to study that was out of the chaos of your home. Another coffee could just have been a habit purchase. You look at your list and realize that whenever you go to the store, you pick up a drink there or on the way. You don't know why, you barely remember it, it's just a thing you always do. The same purchase, made for different reasons, was both something you loved and something you didn't. That's why it's important to make a note of what triggered each of your purchases on that initial overview of your inventory.

As you're understanding more about your habits and spending behaviors, you can make intentional spending decisions that don't cut out an entire category, just the transactions that are mindless and don't get you what you love. Coffee isn't the enemy. The location is not the enemy. Ultimately, we want your goal to be to know what you're buying and the reason you're buying it.

There is no perfect list of values-aligned expenses and no perfect order to arrange them in. But you can make a pretty good one by writing down the things you've identified you value buying and then ordering them from what matters most to what matters less. Everything on your list will matter, but the things at the top of the list will matter most.

Cutting out things you are used to buying or only buying the things at the tippy-top of your "what matters most list" will be hard. Even though you did the work of prioritizing and named the things you want to say no to for now, it will still be difficult to interrupt deeply ingrained patterns. This is why we say values-based spending requires sacrifice, but it's not deprivation. You may feel sad about saying no to things you once said yes to without thinking, but prioritizing makes sure you're always getting the things that you love most, so it's not complete destitution.

When I (Jill) went through this process, it meant prioritizing paying cash for our house renovations for two years. After that, I shifted my focus to invest more heavily in our retirement accounts. For my friend Rachel, she's